

Bash Shortcuts & History Cheat Sheet

Move, edit, find and rerun commands at the bash prompt without retyping them.

Using it

Ctrl-a ← hold Ctrl and press a

Alt-f ← hold Alt and press f (or tap Esc, then f). macOS Terminal: Settings > Profiles > Keyboard > Use Option as Meta key

Moving and editing the line

Key	Does	Key	Does
Ctrl-a / Ctrl-e	Jumps to start / end of the line	Ctrl-u	Cuts from the cursor to the line start
Alt-b / Alt-f	Back / forward one word	Ctrl-k	Cuts from the cursor to the line end
Ctrl-xx	Toggles between line start and cursor	Ctrl-w / Alt-d	Cuts the word before / after the cursor
Alt-.	Pastes the last command's last argument	Ctrl-y	Pastes what you last cut
Tab / Tab Tab	Completes a name / lists all choices	Ctrl-_	Undo (repeat to undo more)
Ctrl-l	Clears the screen, keeps your line	Ctrl-x Ctrl-e	Edits the line in your \$EDITOR

Controlling programs

Key	Does	Key	Does
Ctrl-c	Stops the running command / drops the line	Ctrl-s	Freezes the terminal output
Ctrl-d	End of input; on an empty prompt, logs out	Ctrl-q	Unfreezes it. Frozen terminal? Press Ctrl-q
Ctrl-z	Suspends the command (fg resumes it)	reset	Fixes a garbled terminal (type it blind)

Reading the output: Ctrl-r history search

(reverse-i-search)`rest': sudo systemctl restart nginx ← type any part of a command; the newest match appears
← Ctrl-r again = older match · Enter = run it · arrow key = edit it first · Ctrl-g = cancel
(failed reverse-i-search)`rest': ... ← no (older) match: Backspace or Ctrl-g

History expansion: reuse earlier commands

Type	Means	Type	Means
!!	The whole last command: sudo !!	!501 / !-2	Command no. 501 / the one before last
!\$	Last argument: mkdir /srv/app, cd !\$	!ssh	The newest command starting with ssh
!*	All arguments of the last command	^old^new	Last command, first old changed to new
!rm:p	Add :p to print it, not run it		Bash echoes the expanded command first

The history command

Type	Does	Type	Does
history grep ssh	Finds old commands	HISTSIZE=10000	Commands kept in memory
history 20	Shows the last 20	HISTFILESIZE=20000	Lines kept in ~/.bash_history
history -d 501	Deletes entry 501	HISTCONTROL=ignoreboth	Skips repeats, space-led lines
secret-cmd	Space first: not saved*	HISTTIMEFORMAT='%F %T '	Adds date and time to the list

501 2026-10-03 09:14:22 sudo systemctl restart nginx ← number (for !501) · date and time · command

Put settings in ~/.bashrc. * Needs ignorespace or ignoreboth (Ubuntu's default). History is written to the file when the shell exits.

Brace expansion and folders

Type	Becomes	Type	Does
cp file{,.bak}	cp file file.bak	cd -	Goes back to the previous folder
mkdir -p a/{b,c}	mkdir -p a/b a/c	pushd /etc	Goes to /etc, remembers the old folder
echo {1..5}	echo 1 2 3 4 5	popd	Returns to the remembered folder

Remember: **sudo !!** reruns your last command with sudo. Lost a command? **Ctrl-r** and type a piece of it.